FROM THE
EDITOR-IN-CHIEF

After a nearly year-long lull, India has a major state election at hand again. The big stage this time is Bihar and the stakes go well beyond who controls its 243-seat assembly. The contest has taken an intriguing turn with a trio of protagonists: the seasoned incumbent CM Nitish Kumar, the challenger Tejashwi Yadav and the disruptor Prashant Kishor. Their clash has turned a traditional bipolar battlefield into an unpredictable triangular contest with outcomes that would carry national resonance. Nitish's JD(U) is a critical ally for the BJP at the Centre. Any sign of falling popularity in Bihar will affect the NDA's narrative of pan-India consolidation. Also, any gains by the Opposition INDIA bloc could dangerously tilt the scales ahead of the critical elections in West Bengal and Assam next year. An assembly poll result poses no immediate threat to the backing of the JD(U)'s 12 Lok Sabha MPs. Still, the BJP cannot afford any risk of being thrust into singular dependence on other allies, such as Chandrababu Naidu. Moreover, despite its own ambitions, the BJP has no pan-Bihar leader and may find it prudent to let its sails guide Nitish's ship.

But the persona of Nitish is both an asset and a liability. With reports of failing health, his days as a change-maker seem largely behind him. Having reigned for nearly 20 years straight, seemingly without a sunset clause, he now invites a touch of voter fatigue. Moreover, of the voting public of roughly 74.2 million that the Special Intensive Revision of electoral rolls has left in play, around one-fourth are in the 18-29 age-group. This cohort of young, aspirational and digitally connected voters would have little or no living memory of 2005, when the Nitish era began properly. Yet, the JD(U) helmsman retains a unique bouquet of loyal voters: non-Yadav OBC groups, Extreme Backwards and women. The last one is a crucial component. Women have been outvoting men by about 6-7 percentage points for a decade in Bihar. No wonder the NDA is wooing this segment with a welfare blitzkrieg: over 12 million women have already got Rs 10,000 in their bank accounts as seed capital under a self-employment scheme.

Another axis of volatility within the NDA is now stable. In the 2020 election, the JD(U)'s seat tally had decreased from 71 to 43, a historic low. It was Chirag Paswan's Lok Janshakti Party (LJP) that played the spoiler by going solo, garnering over 10 per cent of the votes in the 135 seats it contested. The LJP won only one seat but thwarted a JD(U) victory in about 34 seats. This time, significantly, Chirag is back with the NDA, bringing his five per cent Paswan vote bank. That, combined with Nitish's Mahadalit support, rebuilds the entire rainbow for the NDA. The only suspense lies in the BJP's refusal to name Nitish as its chief ministerial face, keeping its options open for post-poll manoeuvres.

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The Opposition alliance is not without its own uncertainties. Tejashwi, who has been twice deputy chief minister, has been marking time for what he sees as his inevitable coronation, backed by a 22 per cent vote share in 2024, the highest among all. His partner, the Congress, too, is buoyed by a strong Rahul Gandhi-led roadshow on the 'vote *chori*' plank, which briefly set the narrative alight. Yet two hurdles remain in translating that into a critical mass of seats. Tejashwi must move beyond his Muslim-Yadav bastion and blunt the distrust many harbour for the RJD. The Congress, too, has to overcome its image as the weak link of the alliance. In 2020, it was unable to carry its own weight, winning only 19 of the 70 seats it contested. Will the new Rahul persona galvanise crossover votes to the RJD and itself, especially from the 19.65 per cent Dalits and 36 per cent EBCs? The two are going in with a renewed Mandal 2.0 thrust, tying the promise of job creation in a stagnant economy to an expansion of reservations, including into the private sector.

But then there's a wild card who could upset both sets of calculations: the media-savvy Prashant Kishor. In his previous avatar as poll strategist, PK has famously consorted with Modi, Nitish, and Rahul. Now, in the strategy he's scripting for himself, he's a foe to all three. Making dramatic allegations against NDA bigwigs and painting the RJD as regressive dynasts, he's offering a system reboot of Bihar. As a third force, his Jan Suraaj is targeting the youth voter and all those disillusioned with the system. His 'post-caste' appeal could cut both ways, attracting RJD fence-sitters looking for a fresh Opposition voice, but also, as a Brahmin himself, capable of dipping into the BJP's 15 per cent-plus forward-caste reservoir. In an election with razor-thin margins, even small shifts could create drastically divergent outcomes, and not only for himself. As he himself frames it, it's arsh ya farsh (the sky or the floor). For this week's cover story, Senior Editor Amitabh Srivastava examines all the X-factors in a fascinating SWOT analysis of each contender in a triangular contest brimming with volatility. Bihar has long been a bellwether. This time, it is also a laboratory for the future shape of national politics. When the dust settles, only one side of the triangle will remain standing, hopefully, with nothing left hanging.

(Aroon Purie)